Literature Review: Exchange, Society, and the Himalayan Salt Economy

1.1 Introduction

The salt resource has played a unique role in the course of human history. As a life-sustaining resource available unevenly across the land, it has influenced modes of movement, trade, political power, and social organisation in many different civilisations. The scholarship related to salt has considered topics of trade, taxation, monopoly, and imperialism while pointing at the economic importance of the resource for sustaining life and generating income (Lally, 2021; Taylor, 2023). These studies have enhanced our understanding of salt as a strategic good, especially in colonial administration and distant trade. Thus, it is necessary to look past the physical characteristics of salt and investigate the social institutions influencing the circulation of the resource.

Such an approach will be especially important for the study of the Himalaya region. The Western Himalaya was home to one of the planet's most biodiverse mountain ranges and included such elements as pastoral steppes, agriculturally cultivated valleys, monasteries, and frontier markets within a culturally diverse territory with an intricate system of trade and exchange. Salt from the saline lakes of Changthang flowed with pashm, wool, grain, tea, livestock, and other merchandise to connect peoples who inhabited different ecological zones (Rizvi, 1996, pp. 97–103). The Tibetan and Himalayan salt trade has attracted growing scholarship, and this chapter reviews these strands and their significance. Historians have generally focused on the structure of the salt trade, while anthropologists pay close attention to the details of everyday economic exchange and exchange systems, particularly salt extraction, pastoral mobility, and the spatial and social dimension of *netsang*—a system of fictive kinship that created exchange partnerships between different families across ecological zones. Rather than working out each exchange individually, traders established lasting relationships which were based on trust, hospitality, and obligations. These relationships minimised the uncertainty of trade in regions limited by the elevation, weather, and politics. In the case of the Himalayas, trade existed because the social relations already existed; exchange did not create these relations but rather confirmed them continuously. Such research helps us understand the ancient trans-Himalayan trade. It is also useful to consider how this trade has changed during the 19th and 20th centuries due to colonial rule, assimilation, and taxes.

Theoretical perspectives developed within anthropology, economic history and social theory provide an important framework for interpreting these historical processes. In the twentieth century researchers started challenging the concept that markets were the foundation of all economic relations. Marcel Mauss claimed that early forms of exchange were based on reciprocity rather than on contract, and Karl Polanyi explained that non-market economies were embedded in other social institutions and were not separate from them. Following in this tradition, James C. Scott and E. P. Thompson explored the moral aspects of economic

behaviour, stressing the significance of custom, subsistence values, and conceptions of justice among common people's reactions to political and economic transformations (Thompson, 1971). More recently, scholars like Prasannan Parthasarathi pointed out that markets were constructed politically during colonial times, arguing that capitalism was a product of state intervention in history, and not a development from prior forms of economic organisation (Parthasarathi, 2011). Such ideas provide a theoretical perspective that can be used to see the exchange as an institution, not just as an economic activity.

For the analysis of the Himalayan salt economy, this theoretical background is necessary. Instead of providing a comprehensive analysis of each scholar's work separately, this chapter synthesises the key debates about exchange, embedded economies, moral economy, and colonial transformation of exchange systems, to place these debates within Himalayan historiography. It does not seek to force a theory upon historiography but identifies concepts that help explain the economy of salt production, exchange, and trade in the Himalayas. This emphasis on social relationships also raises the question of how connections between communities, institutions and places can be traced across historical sources. It informs the thesis's use of computational analysis to examine these connections, guided by the historical and anthropological perspectives reviewed here.

The chapter is organised into three substantive sections. The first focuses on the literature of gift-exchange systems as studied by Marcel Mauss and Karl Polanyi, and their rejection of the market-centred view of economic life. The second section looks at the issues surrounding moral economy and colonial change, using the work of James C. Scott, E.P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi to look at how systems of exchange were transformed under colonial capitalism. The third section examines Himalayan historiography and studies the historiography and anthropology of salt, its ecological setting, and social formations within it.

1.2 Exchange, Reciprocity, and the Embedded Economy

The manner in which societies organised production and exchange before the rise of market capitalism has been one of the fundamental issues in economic anthropology. Questioning the assumptions made by classical economics regarding individual rationality and commercial exchange, Mauss and Polanyi answered this question by studying the obligations and institutions whereby societies acquired their subsistence.

In his book *The Gift*, Marcel Mauss decisively broke away from earlier evolutionary theories that saw the evolution of exchange as a process from barter to markets. Not attempting to explain how commercial exchanges evolved, but rather why gifts, which seemed voluntary, created obligations between people and societies, Mauss transformed anthropologists' view of exchange. According to him, gifts were not just transfers of goods; they represented "total social facts" wherein economics was inextricable from law, religion, politics, morality, and community identity (Mauss, 2001, pp. 3, 100-101).

Mauss' formula is based on the fact that the process of exchange depends on three interlinked obligations – the obligation to give, the obligation to receive, and the obligation to reciprocate (Mauss, 2001, chs 1-2). This system turned exchange into a mechanism which constantly recreated social relations. Declining to give indicated one's irresponsibility to the society; declining to accept refused the social relation proposed by the giver; not reciprocating meant losing one's honour and reputation. Thus, the exchange was not regulated by any legal norms or financial calculation but only by the reciprocal obligations and recognition by the community. The value of goods was defined not by accumulation but by circulation, and people's prestige was connected to their ability to enter into these social relations.

Mauss demonstrates this system in the example of Potlatch, which took place among Indigenous peoples of the north-west coast of North America. At those spectacular ceremonies the chiefs distributed, consumed and even destroyed considerable amounts of wealth in front of the gathered communities. In terms of economic rationality, this activity looks unreasonable and economically irrational. Yet Mauss demonstrates that their significance lay precisely in their capacity to establish political authority, social prestige, and collective legitimacy. Wealth was accumulated to be given away, and generosity itself functioned as a source of power (Mauss, 2001, ch. 2).

Mauss' concept of *hau* or *mana* concerns the spiritual essence that lived in the object of exchange in Polynesia. For example, the gift was not treated as a separate commodity detachable from its owner, but as an object infused with the spirit of the giver, which made the recipient responsible due to the ongoing duties (Mauss, 2001, ch. 1). Thus, not returning a gift not only meant being economically indebted but also breaking social, religious, and political ties.

Even though Mauss has successfully outlined the social aspects of exchange, his explanation was mostly focused on the process of exchange and the obligations created by it. Karl Polanyi has broadened the scope of this concept even further, asking the following question: if exchange is socially embedded, then how did entire economies work prior to the creation of the market society?

Polanyi's distinction between formalist and substantivist economics is one of the most influential interventions in twentieth-century economic anthropology. Formalist economics views economic actions as a rational choice based on conditions of scarcity, and hence assumes that market actions serve as a general model for the analysis of any society. Polanyi rejected this assumption by arguing that this is because the said definition is based on the historical conditions of capitalism, not the economy of societies in general. Substantively speaking, an economy consists only of the institutions through which societies make their material living (Polanyi, 1957, pp. 243–250).

While Mauss analyses the social relations created through gift giving, Polanyi analyses the institutionally based organisation of entire economies. As part of this broader concept of economy, Polanyi identified three major forms of economic organisation in pre-market societies: reciprocity, redistribution, and householding. Reciprocity included social transactions involving groups bound to each other through social relations of enduring nature. Redistribution included

collection of commodities from centralised political or religious locations and distribution in the society. Householding included the production of goods for the consumption of a relatively self-sufficient group. The markets did exist but played an auxiliary role in these institutions rather than regulating society (Polanyi, 2001, ch. 4).

These perspectives provide an important conceptual foundation for understanding historical exchange in frontier regions such as the Himalayas. A simple market perspective is not enough to analyse the movement of goods over long distances, since these goods were often transported through institutions based on kinship relations, customary obligations, ecological interdependence, and political power (Rizvi, 1996, pp. 97–103). Therefore, exchange was more than simply the transfer of goods; it was the reproduction of larger social relations that allowed people to live in difficult environments. However, embedded economics was not stagnant; rather, it underwent transformation as colonial states expanded, market economies emerged, and labour became more regulated. In order to comprehend this transformation, one must move from embedded exchange to the topics of moral economy and colonial political economy, which will be the subject matter of the next section.

1.3 Moral Economy, Colonial Transformation, and the Making of Markets

The growth of capitalist markets, the establishment of state power, and changes in the conditions of work radically transformed the previous relations of reciprocity, redistribution, and traditional exchange. Historians and political economists therefore examine how these pre-market societies saw the rise of market capitalism rather than the way in which pre-market societies operated. An important part of this research lies in understanding that markets did not replace the previous types of exchange due to economic effectiveness and technical development. Rather, they were historically produced through political intervention, institutional restructuring, and changing relations of power (Parthasarathi, 2011). The writings of James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi have shaped this approach, although all of them study the problem from a different historical perspective.

The idea of the moral economy of James C. Scott deals with issues of subsistence and exchange. Speaking about agrarian Southeast Asia mainly, James C. Scott criticised the interpretation of peasants' activities as being driven mainly by profit maximisation. He asserted that subsistence was the core organising principle of peasants' economy. Communities on the verge of ecology and economy were concerned with minimising risk in their activities and not with maximising their profit. It is the "safety first" principle that determined decisions about production, labour, and exchange (Scott, 1976, p. 5). Thus, the economic decisions were based on the necessity of preserving the subsistence level.

Pre-capitalist societies were also based on moral expectations of reciprocal obligations between rulers and their subjects. These obligations were not only within the community, but included

landlords, village elites and authorities, whose moral obligation was to sustain the livelihood of those whom they were ruling at times of crisis. Consequently, legitimacy was not only dependent on legal sovereignty, but also on adhering to the social and reciprocal obligations (Scott, 1976, chs 2 and 6). Breach of these obligations in terms of taxes, revenue demands, and extraction resulted in more than economic problems; they were considered violations of the prevailing moral expectations. The resistance that resulted from this was not due to any ideological beliefs, but rather from attempts to uphold the existing moral expectations.

This approach, although developed in a different historical context, can be very useful when analysing frontier economies which are characterised by uncertainty and seasonal exchanges. Reciprocity, custom and assistance were not only cultural practices but environmental management strategies. Thus, economic exchanges were linked with social security and contributed to the broader idea of Mauss and Polanyi that markets did not form the organising principles of pre-capitalist societies.

E. P. Thompson developed a related but distinct view and formulated the notion of moral economy through his research in eighteenth-century England. Similarly to Mauss and Polanyi, Thompson did not see the reasons for the collective action of the protesters in purely economic terms, emphasizing instead the fact that those actions were primarily based on the traditional ideas of justice, rights, and legitimacy rather than mere starvation. In his study of food riots, Thompson revealed that communities tended to preserve the traditional principles of distribution of vital resources, especially those challenged by market relations (Thompson, 1971, pp. 76–79). Therefore, markets could not only be seen as new economic institutions but also as a challenge to established social relations and traditional views on what was considered just.

The wider contribution of Thompson can be summarised as an idea that historical development should not be analysed in terms of economic development. Specifically, Thompson distinguishes between a "standard-of-life" and a "way-of-life", showing how processes of capitalist transformation often challenged customary institutions and practices of community, as well as the local autonomy even in cases when material conditions improved (Thompson, 1963, ch. 6). It becomes clear then that the distinction helps to identify forms of dispossession that cannot be revealed by standard economic analysis.

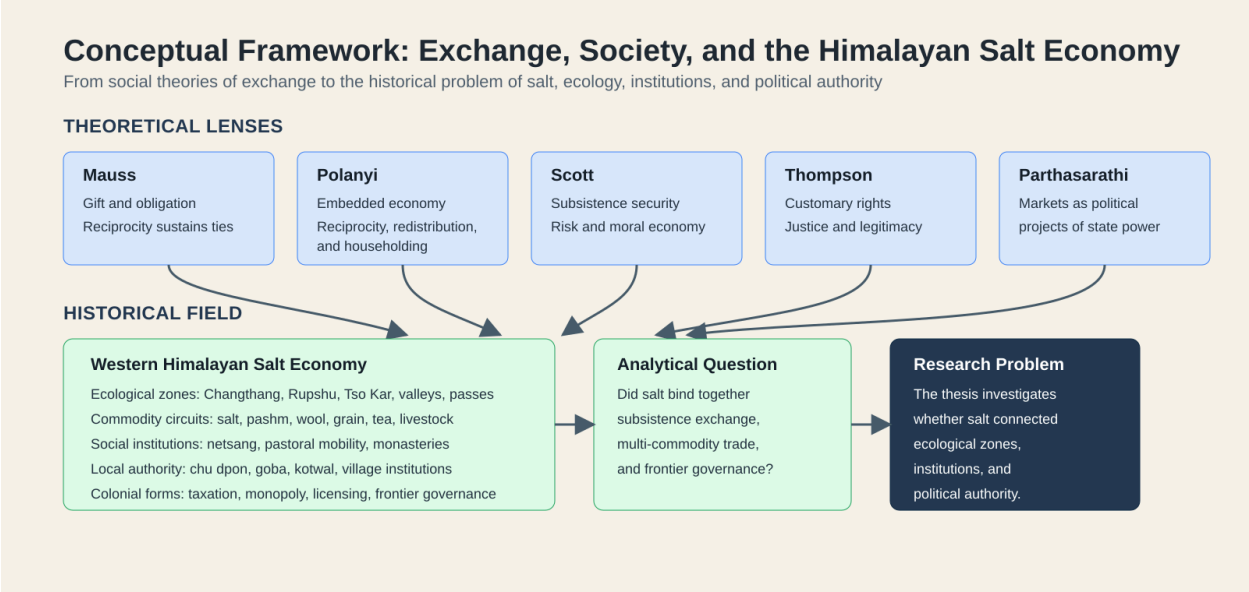
In comparison to Scott's emphasis on the subsistence ethic of agricultural societies, Thompson has focused on the rights and institutions undermined by the spread of market connections. Transition to capitalist markets thus required not only the creation of new modes of exchange but also the reconfiguration of social arrangements that governed production, distribution, and resource access in earlier times. These discussions have been extended by Prasannan Parthasarathi, who, with his analysis of labour, industry, and colonial political economy, offers a perspective that contests the view of capitalism as an outcome of economic predominance of Europe. Through comparative analysis of South Asia on a global scale, Parthasarathi contends that markets are not autonomous and historically predestined entities but are created by political choices that redefine labour and production arrangements. Colonial intervention therefore played a decisive role in reorganising existing economies, not by introducing markets into

previously isolated societies, but by altering the conditions under which production and exchange were organised (Parthasarathi, 2001, pp. 1–10; 2011).

Parthasarathi's intervention shifts attention from exchange alone to the broader political economy of colonialism. The creation of new market relationships that favoured the interests of imperialism over the pre-existing systems of production was achieved through labour regimes, commerce, law, and the state (Parthasarathi, 2001).

Collectively, the works of Scott, Thompson, and Parthasarathi expand on the institutional analysis suggested by Mauss and Polanyi through their consideration of customary rights, subsistence requirements, labour relations, and political authority amid periods of economic change. While operating in different historical contexts, these authors have illustrated how the organisation of production and exchange affected relationships among communities, employers, merchants, and rulers. Consequently, their studies can serve as an analytical tool for studying the responsibilities that made economic relations possible and the interventions that transformed them. Furthermore, their approach draws one's attention to the uneven impacts of such changes, as economic arrangements that enabled business success for certain actors undermined the safety and/or customary rights of others.

This perspective is especially pertinent to the Himalayan economy of salt, which was based on access to resources, seasonal movement, labour organisation, and the interactions between trading communities and political authorities. From this theoretical perspective, one should focus on the interplay between the reciprocity, commercial calculations, customary rights, and regulation in such arrangements. The nature of this interplay and any changes in it require specific historical investigation. The following section therefore turns to Himalayan scholarship, comparing how historians and anthropologists have interpreted the organisation of salt production and exchange, the authority exercised over them, and their transformation across different regions and periods.



1.4 Salt, economy, and political authority in the Himalayas

The mobility of salt created economic relationships between communities in the Himalayas and more extensive networks of exchange and political power. These relationships were created through mechanisms which controlled production, transportation and access. This paper reviews the interpretations of the connections made by historical and anthropological research with respect to regional production, reciprocity, labour organization in Rupshu, rituals and rights claims. Historical interpretation of the relationship between customary and state institutions is not a matter of transition from one system to the other but a historical problem. Primary attention will be paid to Ladakh and Rupshu-Tso Kar region; while Tibetan, Nepali, Kumauni and Kinnauri scholarship will provide comparisons.

Ecological differences are responsible for these exchanges. The pastoral plateaus provided salt, wool, pashm and livestock, while valleys provided grain and other supplies. Lazcano distinguishes the Changthang lake sources, the Tsaidam salt region of Amdo, and Tsakalho's terraced saltpans on the upper Mekong (2022, p. 71). These were different production settings, rather than interchangeable parts of one Himalayan economy. Rizvi described there was an exchange in October at Chemrey-Sakti, where Chang-pa brought the salt from plateau lakes on sheep's backs and villagers from all Ladakh came to exchange it for grain. Shamma traders acquired salt in bulk and carried it to the Suru valley and Baltistan, exchanging it for grain or dried apricots; the apricots could subsequently be sold for cash in Leh or Srinagar. These journeys connected pastoral salt production, agricultural provisioning, and further commercial exchanges (Rizvi, 1996, p. 100). The significance of salt also lay in the network through which people sourced things not found locally, but ecological complementarity does not account for trade control and benefits.

Journeys depended on the household's labour and animals, and on weather conditions. As Rizvi says, some Shamma traders could be absent from their village for up to ten months a year. Their travels were possible due to family cooperation: generally speaking, one member of the household did the trading business, and others, including his brothers, wife, and unmarried sisters, continued farming. Long-distance commerce could therefore proceed while cultivation continued at home (Rizvi, 1996, p. 100). Ahmed states that small herd owners went with large ones to Tibetan salt lakes in exchange for help (1999, p. 33), which is an example of how different transport resources affected the possibility to participate in trading. In Tso Kar, the salt extraction was done in September or October; however, weather conditions (rainfall and drying) could change its timing (p. 41, note 21). So ecological time did not allow fixed calendar of travels in the region. The link between pastoralism and trading also consisted of certain practical issues and inequality of opportunities.

Rizvi also complicates the idea of clear division between subsistence and trade. She distinguishes salt–grain–wool exchange from the higher-value pashm trade but shows how Shamma traders participated in both. They sold pashm for cash, bought salt, and made gains through further exchanges (Rizvi, 1996, pp. 99–100). Calculation and profits were also possible with barter exchanges. The exchange of salt linked pastoral production, agricultural provision, and trade, thus forming a basis upon which to reconstruct commodity networks within the Himalayas. This thesis takes salt as an anchor around which to reconstruct such commodity networks by asking how and to what extent the exchange of salt routes and relations provided the basis of a network of commodity relations in the Himalayas.

The social organisation of exchange likewise requires attention to commerce alongside obligation. Lecoq describes Nepalese caravan traders staying with established ceremonial partners who provided food, accommodation, and a pen for their animals. The traders reciprocated with highland products such as wool, butter, and cheese, and the partners agreed the terms of barter (2022, p. 48). The relations offered concrete support for travels during which traders procured food for their trips. Similarly, Rizvi writes that joint-family arrangement facilitated Shamma traders in making profitable trading trips even as the rest of the family carried on agricultural work (1996, pp. 99-100). Such cooperation made food and agricultural labour available during trading.

Ahmed's Rupshu study moves the analysis from circulation to the organisation of salt collection. Each household was required to send a man to the salt march or arrange for a relative to collect its share. The men worked in teams known as *chu lag*. Although team members could be related, they did not necessarily belong to the same *pha spun*, or patri-fraternal group (1999, pp. 41–42). Within each team, some men broke the salt crust, others filled tins, and others carried the salt to the bank. While working together in this way, each man had his own heap of salt, identified his own share, and loaded his own saddle bags (pp. 42-43). Thus, cooperation was organising the labour of extraction; however, the extracted salt belonged in identifiable shares taken back home by each participant.

Allocation brings into sharper focus these differences. Four groups of extraction labour are mentioned by Ahmed where there is a *chu dpon*, division of the lake by kotwal, and the order of

selection is decided with the help of dice. A requirement to fill twenty-five saddle-bags followed complaints about unequal extraction by larger herd owners (1999, p. 42). These types of regulations point out attempts to balance conflicting interests in collective labour processes. Salt, after being collected, was sent for different purposes such as household use, religious offerings, barter, and sale (p. 45). Thus, not every move could be seen as an equal exchange since the same commodity was involved in connecting lives, duties, and access rights.

Male Tibetan salt expeditions are described by Lazcano as having roles based on family structure with offering, cooking, learning from apprentices, and tending to animals. These were the roles of a caravan but not of an ordinary Rupshu household. A restricted salt terminology and the rules about local deities show the connection between work and ritual (Lazcano, 2022, pp. 71-72). Women's labour is mentioned by Lazcano regarding Tsakalho (pp. 83-84), while Ahmed talks about men regarding male identity and connection to Tso Kar (1999, p. 47). Herein is the evidence of how production and mobility produced certain social identifications and not simply the division of labour among the Himalayan groups.

Rights to resources were yet another source of conflicts as described by Ahmed involving monasteries, local leaders, administrative organs and courts of Rupshu and Kharnak (1999, pp. 43–45). The disputes concerned pasture and land as well as salt. Monasteries could receive contributions or support competing claims, so religious institutions cannot collectively be treated as neutral centres of redistribution. Customary authority involves negotiation, exclusion and implementation of the power. Customary, religious and administrative powers intertwined in the process of dispute resolution.

Ahmed also complicates a continuous history of Tso Kar extraction. Earlier written descriptions and retrospective accounts do not establish an agreed chronology before the 1960s (1999, pp. 38–40). Legends about the lake and interactions between the people of the hidden valley provide insights into the cultural memory, yet are unable to prove the chronology of the commercial activities. Preferences for the salt used in butter tea shed additional light on the persistence of the trade regardless of its low yields (pp. 46–47). Salt’s value could include taste, identity, and attachment as well as price. The literature therefore requires distinguishing accounts of meaning from evidence of when, where, and how much salt was produced or traded.

The political interpretation becomes more specific through Alam’s study of Mandi. He links intervention in salt administration, payment, and labour arrangements with popular grievances and royal authority, interpreting the reforms as a successful conversion to cash (Alam, 2007, pp. 175–178). Mandi can be regarded as a particular place where the effect of economy on politics can be studied. It cannot represent the whole Himalayan salt production as different was the administration of mines compared to the lakes and princes compared to villagers.

The analysis by Bergmann of the Kumaon case of negotiations over land revenue and taxes on trade duties also qualifies that narrative of replacement. He illustrates how British authorities sought to accommodate competing claims while maintaining their commercial access (2016, pp. 96–98). Intervention in politics could offer protections as much as constraints. In Alam’s

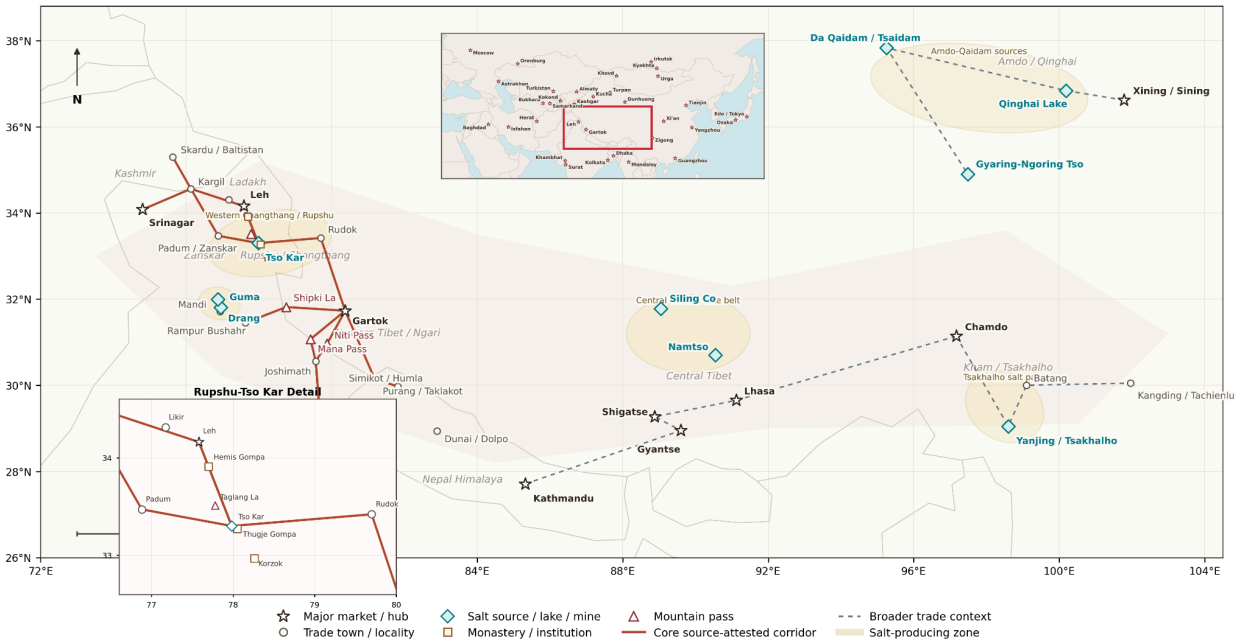
comparison of the Lavi fair and the Shimla market, commodity flows were central to the making of commercial space and borders (2021, pp. 173–174). Here the works have already made sense of circulation politically. The thesis can develop their arguments through salt-focused comparison, but should not describe existing scholarship as merely descriptive or claim to discover Himalayan interconnectedness.

Wider salt historiography provides a comparative context. For instance, Lally's work on colonial Burma focuses on negotiations of sovereignty and uneven administration of fiscal policy, whereas Taylor analyses producers and merchants' interests in the Indian salt supply and regulation (Lally, 2021; Taylor, 2023). The two works thus differentiate political authority from uniform administration and interests of consumers from those of producers and merchants. Their significance is in the issues they pose for Himalayan evidence, rather than in any similarities in systems in the region.

Historical change also followed different regional chronologies. Dollfus's Kharnak account and Singh and colleagues' Rupshu study connect major changes with border restrictions after 1962, military presence, provisioning, and shifting livelihoods (Dollfus, 2012, pp. 66-68; Singh et al., 2013, PDF pp. 6, 9-10). This is different from colonial fiscal intervention. In the Kinnaur case described by Beszterda, the subsequent commodity combination is made possible by cheap plain salt and involves currency-based calculation along with settlement in goods (2017, pp. 39, 45). Reopening a route therefore does not necessarily restore its earlier economic organisation. Participants, commodities, transport, and regulatory conditions may all have changed.

In this literature, ecological interconnectedness, commercial calculation, social obligation, and political power often go hand in hand. What makes these cases different is the mode of production, access, gendered labour, and the way and timing of change. The differences reveal the connection between circulation and power in historically specific ways. They also prevent social embeddedness from becoming an assertion that exchange was harmonious, stable, or equal. Their differences also require separating consumers' demands from the rights and obligations of the people who extracted and transported the salt.

This thesis seeks to examine if salt connected certain goods, communities, locations, and authorities in a particular corpus of Western Himalayas. Circulation and governance in relation to each other will form the research question to be explored using certain historical examples. Comparative study of the relations provided by the sources will help enrich the regional studies without losing distinctions in time and jurisdiction. It still needs to be shown that the connective role of salt was there. The following chapter examines the documentary evidence and its limits before the methodology and results chapters assess these relationships.



1.5 Conclusion

However, it is evident from the literature discussed in this chapter that exchange cannot be considered only as an economic process determined by the dynamics of the market alone. Anthropologists, economic historians, and political economists have always been against the idea that the market is the natural and universal form of economic organisation (Polanyi, 1944/2001). It is clear from the writings of Marcel Mauss, Karl Polanyi, James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi that economic activity has been embedded in larger processes of reciprocity, custom, politics, ecology, and morality. While these authors may vary in terms of their historical periods and focus areas, they are unanimous in their rejection of market universalism and in their emphasis on the social and political institutions organising exchange. Collectively, these authors give us a useful framework for studying societies where economic activity cannot be divorced from the rest of social life.

This theoretical framework will be helpful in understanding the history of the Himalayan salt economy. Apart from being a trade good, salt has been important in relation to pastoral nomadism, ecology, religion, and politics. Historical and anthropological research has shown that its distribution was based on reciprocity, caravan arrangements, redistribution by monasteries, customary regulations, and ecological complementarity. Consequently, the operation of trade in the Western Himalayas was based on social structures in which people interacted in long-term associations through geographical divisions. Not only was salt a commodity, but also the means by which societies engaged with survival, power, and dependency within the context of a fragmented geographic frontier (Ahmed, 1999, pp. 43–45).

On the other hand, the reviewed studies suggest that such systems of embedded trading were neither static nor cut off from other historical processes. Colonial governance changed these structures through taxation, monopoly, licensing, frontier governance, and growing bureaucratisation. However, these changes did not affect only the ways trade patterns were structured; they affected the socio-political relationships used to organise such trading relations. Consequently, the Himalayan salt economy must be understood not only in terms of commodity circulation but also as part of a broader history of state formation, frontier governance, and colonial political economy.

Thus, the key challenge in this context is that of reconstructing relations among different goods, routes, institutions, and political authorities. This study is placed in such a historiographical setting. The aim of this thesis is to complement these pieces of academic research through presenting archival evidence on salt trade in the Western Himalayas. In doing so, it uses an interdisciplinary methodology based on historical analysis of archival evidence to explore the interconnections between commodities, routes, institutions and political agents. The goal is not only the recreation of individual instances of trade but also to make sense of the broader networks by means of which salt influenced frontier economies and politics in the colonial era. In this regard, computational approaches can aid in identifying connections between scattered archival accounts (Painter et al., 2019). Social and historical approaches covered in this chapter provide a basis for interpreting the outcomes of this analysis.

The following chapter therefore moves from theoretical and historiographical discussions to the historical sources themselves. It reviews the primary archival sources, such as gazetteers, colonial administration reports, treaties, travel accounts, and Foreign Department records which describe the movement of salt in the Western Himalayas. The archives provide the empirical foundation for constructing historical networks of connections formed through the salt trade.

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